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Source: *Numen*, Sep., 1957, Vol. 4, Fasc. 3 (Sep., 1957), pp. 171-203

Published by: Brill

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DIVINE KINGSHIP IN ANCIENT CHINA

BY

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INTRODUCTION

For nearly three thousand years in China, until the abolition of the monarchy in 1911, the emperor was the focus of those ritual activities by which the prosperity and well-being of the whole empire were established from year to year. The ritual was designed to harmonize all human life and activities with the cosmic forces which governed heaven and earth, and, at the same time, it constituted an attempt to control the unpredictable elements of human experience.

From the earliest historical times the civilization of China was based on an agricultural economy ¹), in which man's primary interests were concerned with birth and death, procreation and fertility, and the cycle of the seasons. Chinese tradition points to a primitive period in which hunting and fishing were man's principal means of livelihood ²), but there is no mention of a nomadic stage. This accords with the archaeological evidence which reveals that in late Neolithic times the ancestors of the Chinese were already living in comparatively stable settlements, and cultivating the soil ³). It is interesting, therefore, to compare the myth and ritual pattern of Chinese society in early times with that made familiar to us in studies mainly concerned with the Near East, and, in particular, with Egypt and the Mesopotamian sphere of cultural interest. Such a comparison leads us to believe that the concepts which lie behind the Chinese ritual differ fundamentally, in some respects

1) Cf. M. GRANET, *La Civilisation chinoise* (Paris 1929), (E. T. London 1930), p. 139; H. MASPERO, *Les Religions Chinoises* (Paris 1950), p. 19; K. S. LATOURETTE, *The Chinese, their history and culture* (London 1934), p. 34; R. GROSSET, *Histoire de la Chine* (Paris 1942), p. 9 f.

2) Cf. *The I King*, transl. by J. LEGGE (Oxford 1899), p. 382 ff. Also R. WILHELM, *A Short History of Chinese Civilization* (London 1929), p. 59.

3) H. G. CREEL, *The Birth of China* (London 1936), p. 43.

at least, from those which predominated in other civilizations, which were produced in response to the challenge of geographical environments similar to that obtaining in the valley of the Yellow River.

What H. Frankfort wrote concerning the Near East applies equally to the ancient civilization of China: "The ancient Near East considered kingship the very basis of civilization. Only savages could live without a king. Security, peace and justice could not prevail without a ruler to champion them" ⁴). Yet, as far as we know, the emperor of China was never thought of as a god, at least while he was still living on earth. The Chinese emperors, in status and function, approximated more nearly to the rulers of Mesopotamia than to those of Egypt. In Egypt, Pharoah was not mortal, but a god: "This was the fundamental concept of Egyptian kingship that Pharoah was of divine essence, a god incarnate" ⁵). Whereas, in China as in Mesopotamia, "the king was a mortal charged with the crushing burden of leading mankind..... Although his divine election endowed him with a potency surpassing that of ordinary men, it did not approximate him to the gods" ⁶). The Chinese emperor appears to have achieved a quasi-divine status after death, and to have become the object of worship and sacrifice in the ancient cult of ancestors. Though he was not a god, and did not represent a god in the ritual, he alone was given such titles as 'Son of Heaven', (T'ien tzu 天子), and 'unique man' (I jen — 人). The title 'son of Heaven' meets us frequently in the literature of the Western Chou period, early in the first millenium B.C. It does not seem to have implied the concept of 'divine' kingship. The king was entirely human, but he was the 'unique man'. As M. Granet writes ⁷), "S'il est saint, son titre de Fils du Ciel n'implique point qu'il soit pourvu de droit divin". It was by the appointment of Heaven that the king was conceived of as supreme regulator of 'all under Heaven' (T'ien hsia, 天下), and he was considered to stand in a peculiar and unique relationship to Heaven. As 'unique man' the quality of his character, his power or virtue, (te 德) was reflected in all the events and happenings, whether good or evil, within the territories over which

4) H. FRANKFORT, *Kingship and the Gods* (Chicago 1938), p. 3.

5) *Ibid.*, p. 5.

6) *Ibid.*, p. 295.

7) M. GRANET, *La Feodalité Chinoise* (Oslo 1952), p. 101.

he held sway, conceived of as being all within the pale of civilization. His influence was exercised, not only within the world of human affairs, but also over natural processes such as produced prosperity and calamity.

Because of his unique position and status, and his relationship to Heaven, the emperor alone could offer the supreme worship and sacrifice to High Heaven, (Hao T'ien 昊天, Huang T'ien 皇天 Huang T'ien Shang Ti 皇天上帝), and perform those ritual functions by which the favour of Heaven, Earth and the myriad spirits might be assured to the whole land.

Thus, as in other ancient civilizations, the rituals by which the favour of the gods was secured and prosperity assured were focussed in the person of the king. Yet, in China, the pattern of seasonal and symbolic rites which the king undertook to perform on behalf of the land and the people, though originating in a similar chthonic religion in which ancestor worship and fertility cults predominated, in its development seems to differ vastly from that made familiar to us in the writings of the Myth and Ritual school. There seem to be no dramatic representations of the death and rising of a god, no ritual combat to represent the victory of the god over his enemies, no sacred marriage, no triumphal procession in which the king played the role of a god, followed by a train of lesser gods and visiting deities. China had no equivalent of Osiris, Tammuz, Adonis, Astarte, Cybele, and Ceres. Nor does there seem to have developed in the official cult of China a pantheon of celestial deities such as we find in Indo-European religions. There is a parallel in 'Heaven' (T'ien 天) to the concepts of Varuna and Ouranos, but there seems to be no parallel in Chinese religion to the anthropomorphic gods of the Vedic religion in India: — Indra, Rudra, Mitra, Surya, Ushas, Agni —, nor to the personalized gods and goddesses of the Greek Olympus.

The sun and moon, rising and setting and making their orderly progress across the sky, were just as conspicuous in the bright, clear atmosphere of North China as they were in the Near East. The sun was just as potent in providing the light and heat by which men lived. There is evidence that gods, inhabiting the sun, moon and stars, were worshipped in early times in China. In Chinese mythology, the sun is the offspring of a female, Hsi Ho (羲和), who drove his chariot

across the sky harnessed to a team of six dragons. The divine archer, Shen I (神羿), said to have been a minister of the mythical emperor Yao (3rd Millenium B.C.), after performing great exploits, such as vanquishing the wind-god, shooting down nine false suns in the form of crows, and slaying various dangerous creatures, built for himself a solar palace, and became the ruling sovereign of the sun. He married Ch'ang O (嫦娥), sister of the water spirit. She, having stolen the elixir of immortality, went to live in the moon⁸). How far this mythology, current in the Han dynasty, reflects foreign influence, or how far it indicates the beliefs current among the early inhabitants of China we cannot now determine, as the orthodox Chinese literature practically ignores it. We know, however, that Ch'in Shih Huang Ti, in B.C. 219, offered sacrifices to eight great deities, and the Lord of the Sun (Jih Chu, 日主) and the Lord of the Moon (Yueh Chu, 月主) were included among them⁹). Furthermore, in poems of the late Chou and Han dynasties there are frequent descriptions of heavenly journeys in chariots drawn by dragons, following the orbit of the sun¹⁰), whilst of the six emblems depicted on the upper garment of the emperor's state robes, three depicted the sun, moon and stars¹¹). B. Laufer¹²), in discussing the jade symbols of sovereignty, and in particular the jade hammers and knives, writes, "I concur with Prof. de Groot in the opinion that these emblems were originally connected with some form of solar worship. In the Chou period only slight vestiges of this cult appear on the surface; the emblems themselves had then sunk into a more conventional and traditional, nay, an hieroglyphic use within the boundaries of the rigid official system... As these ceremonial insignia point back to primitive implements from which they were developed, so also the ideas as-

8) Cf. W. F. MAYERS, *Chinese Reader's Manual* (Shanghai 1874), pt. 1, No. 235; C. A. S. WILLIAMS, *Outlines of Chinese Symbolism* (Peking 1931), pp. 242, 347; E. T. C. WERNER, *Dict. of Chinese Mythology* (Shanghai 1932), articles: Hou I, Shen I, and Ch'ang O.

9) L. WIEGER, *Textes Historiques* (Hien-hien 1929), p. 211.

10) Cf. *The Poems of Ch'ü Yüan* (Chinese ed. Peking 1953), Ch'u Tz'u Chi Chu.

11) A. BULLING, *The Meaning of China's most ancient art*, Leiden 1952, p. 13.

12) B. LAUFER, *Jade, A Study in Chinese archaeology and religion* (S. Pasadena), p. 102.

sociated with them in the age of the Chou point to a more rudimentary and elementary form of symbolism and worship. The Chou emperor worshipped the sun by holding in his hands the hammer-shaped jade symbol of sovereignty. This means, in my opinion, that at a prehistoric age, a jade (or perhaps common stone) hammer was regarded as the actual image of the solar deity worshipped by the sovereign, and, I believe, that the burial of jade implements in the Chou period was as a last survival also connected with this ancient cult of the sun." It is reasonable to conclude that, in very early times in China, the sun and the moon were worshipped, but within historic times they were always considered to be inferior in status and dependent upon 'Heaven'. The concepts of a sun-god and a moon-god never seem to have played the conspicuous role in Chinese religion which they did in the somewhat similar agricultural civilizations of Egypt and Mesopotamia. China had no equivalent of the Egyptian concept of Ra.

Two main elements lie at the basis of Chinese religion: the cult of ancestors, and the belief in a cosmic order, of which man is only a small part and which he must learn to obey. The ritual pattern, focused in the person and functions of the emperor, is mainly concerned with them. They stem from the chthonic religion which seems to have been common to early man everywhere; the worship of earth deities, natural objects, natural powers and the spirits of deceased ancestors. By the time of the Shang dynasty (circum 1550-1050 B.C.), for which we have positive and reliable evidence¹³), not only was kingship well developed but the earlier chthonic religion had become greatly modified, possibly as a result of new learning which filtered into China from the West in the Early 3rd century of the 2nd millenium B.C., and which probably originated in Mesopotamia¹⁴). The supreme

13) Cf. H. G. CREEL, *Birth of China* (London 1936), pp. 57 ff.; *Studies in Early Chinese Culture* (1938), pp. 133 ff.

14) H. G. QUARITCH WALES, *The Mountain of God* (London 1953), p. 34: "The effective influence from the West reached China about the middle of the second millenium B.C. It may have been instrumental to the founding of the Shang capital Anyang."

p. 38: "That a new religion, as part of a cultural pattern originating in Mesopotamia, was introduced to the Yellow River basin in the middle of the second millenium B.C. is the thesis that I now have to advance. This religion was the cult of the Earth, in very much the same abstract form it had in Mesopotamia, at least before the rise of Babylon."

p. 40: "Then, perhaps through the infiltration of later astral aspects of Meso-

god was conceived of as dwelling above, and the ancestor spirits were thought of as residing in Heaven.

Before going on to discuss the origin and the rise of kingship in China, it is necessary to examine into the prehistoric chthonic religion which continued to exert an influence upon the ritual throughout historic times, and which had a vital connection with the religious status and functions of the king. As far back as we can trace in China the cult of ancestor was linked to the worship of an earth deity, the protective gods of the home, and with nature spirits associated with the

potamian religion, and certainly accentuated about the Vth century B.C. by the influence of Western planetary cosmology, it seems probable that the Chou ancestor was transferred to the sky. There, as a celestial, instead of a merely earthly ancestor, he was identified with some star in the circumpolar region. And the sky also, under the new influences, became the home of the dead, though the old idea, associated with the cult of the Earth, of a home of the dead underground, still lingered on."

The writer is inclined to believe that the astral aspects of Chinese religion are much earlier than the Vth century B.C., and, indeed, go back to at least the Shang dynasty, about the middle of the second millenium B.C. Though, as CREEL writes (*Studies in Early Chinese Culture*, p. 56), "the deity Heaven is absolutely foreign to Shang culture", the oracle bone inscriptions witness to the fact that in Shang times the ancestors of the ruler were conceived of as living above, and a supreme deity, living above, called Ti (帝) was worshipped. In this connection, cf. the able discussion of the use of the word Ti (帝) on the oracle bone inscriptions recorded by Sun Hai P'o (孫海波) in his *Chia Ku Wen Pien* (甲骨文編) by Fu Ssu Nien (傅斯年) in his *Hsing Ming Ku Hsün Pien Cheng*, (性命古訓辨證) Vol. 2. pp. 4 ff. (Chinese text. Shanghai, 1947).

Cf. also Kuo Mo Jo, (郭沫若) *Chia Ku Wen Tzu Yen Chiu*, (甲骨文字研究) chapter on Shih Chih Kan (釋支干) (Chinese text Peking, 1952), for a discussion of Mesopotamian influence on Chinese astral religion.

Cf. H. G. CREEL, *Studies*, p. 251, for an account of Early cultural influence from the West.

For early astral religion in China, cf. DE SAUSSANE, *Les Origines de l'Astronomie Chinoise* (Paris 1930).

H. CHATLEY, Art. *Ancient Chinese Astronomy* in the *Asiatic Review*, Jan. 1918. *The Reprint, The China Society*.

Also, Art. *The Date of the Hsia Calendar*, *Hsia Hsiao Cheng*, *J. R. A. S.*, Oct. 1938.

Cf. also A. BULLING, *The Meaning of China's Most Ancient Art* (Leiden 1952), p. 105.

hills and rivers, the grain and the wild animals¹⁵). "The farther we go back in our investigation of Chinese religion", writes Creel, "and the greater the part played by ancestors"¹⁶). The evidence from neolithic sites reveals that the Chinese, in common with other peoples, had a belief in some form of survival after death. The earth seems to have been thought of as the earliest home of the dead, and it was within the earth that there existed those generative forces which produced the plants and animals on which man sustained and nourished himself throughout life. The vital force, which man felt within himself, came from the earth, lived on the earth, and at death returned to the earth to mingle again with the generative power from which it sprang. For some time after death the vital force might linger near the corpse which had been for so long its home, but, as the corpse disintegrated, the 'soul' must inevitably return to the 'Yellow Springs'¹⁷), that mysterious source of creative energy down in the earth. The cult of ancestors and the fertility cults seem to have had a common origin, as B. Karlgren has argued¹⁸), the early symbols used to depict ancestors, tsu (祖), and earth altars, she (社), being originally written without the determinative shih

15) The protective gods of the home were associated with the inner court, the hearth, the inner doors, the outer gates and the well. Cf. E. CHAVANNES, *Le T'ai Chan* (Paris 1910), p. 438. „Le *tchong lieou* (中霤) était l'une des cinq divinités familiales (五祀) auxquelles on rendait un culte dans l'antiquité, les quatre autres étant: le fourneau (竈) dans lequel brûle le feu domestique, le puits (井) où réside le génie de l'eau, la porte extérieure (門) et les portes intérieures (戶) dont les dieux veillent aux rites de passage qui protègent toute enceinte.”

For the prominence of animals in the early religion of the Chinese cf. DE SAUSSANE, *Art in T'oung Pao*, 1909, p. 264. LAUFER, *Jade: A Study in Chinese Archaeology, and Religion* (S. Pasadena), p. 182. C. A. S. WILLIAMS, *Outlines of Chinese Symbolism* (Peking 1931), pp. 382, 286, 62.

For tree worship: WILLIAMS, *op. cit.*, 374; BULLING, *op. cit.*, 109, 112 ff. For mountains: BULLING, *op. cit.*, pp. 57 and 66; CHAVANNES, *Le T'ai Chan* (Paris 1910), pp. 27 ff.

16) H. G. CREEL, *The Birth of China* (London 1936), p. 174.

17) The Yellow Springs are frequently referred to in Chinese literature as the home of the departed. Cf. the proverbial saying, 'We will not see each other again till we reach the Yellow Springs.' (不及黃泉無相見也).

18) B. KARLGREN, *Bul. Museum Far Eastern Antiquities* (Stockholm 1930), part 2, pp. 1-54.

(示), and depicting a phallic emblem, source of potency and generative power. (A A). M. Granet believed that, in ancient times the Chinese conceived of the earth as feminine. "Earth itself appeared to be a Mother, giving fertility to women and receiving it from them. Thus there was a period when the earth which had been inhabited and claimed had none but female attributes. Organization was then almost entirely matriarchal. Then, when the husbandmen, in creating agnatic institutions, became masters of cultivation, the spirit of the soil seemed to be endowed with masculine traits" ¹⁹). He, too, emphasises the close connection between the cult of ancestors and the fertility cults. "La substance du mort pénétrait dans le Sol familial. Il se désincarnait près du coin sombre où l'on conservait les semences qui, mises en terre, germeraient; et, dans ce même coin, était disposée la couche conjugale où les femmes concevaient des vies nouvelles. Elles imaginaient alors que leur conception était l'oeuvre des Puissances fécondes qui émanaient du Sol domestique, que dans le Sol même avait germé la vie qu'elles sentaient croître en elles, et qu'enfin l'entant qui leur venait avait pris sa substance dans la substance même des aïeux. La croyance s'établit que des principes de vie flottaient dans le coin sombre où les aïeux s'étaient désincarnés: toute naissance parut être une réincarnation d'ancêtre" ²⁰).

We would suggest that, from very early times, the Chinese thought of the earth as possessing feminine traits, but that it was not so much the earth that was worshipped as the spirit of potency by which the earth was made fruitful. This mysterious spiritual potency was evidenced both in man and in natural phenomena, and particularly in the process of growth and productivity. At first the gods that were worshipped were sexually undifferentiated, but later the concept of 'lords of the soil', 'lords of the grain' and 'divine ancestors' grew up. The earth was still thought of as holding in her womb the essential spirit of potency. On this question we might quote Dr. D. C. Graham, "the conception of a mysterious potency, often more or less vague and undefined, but none the less real, is the primary key to the interpretation of the popular religion of the Chinese people, which has come

¹⁹) M. GRANET, *Chinese Civilization* (London 1930), p. 172.

²⁰) M. GRANET, *La Religion des Chinois* (Paris 1951, p. 23. In this connection it is interesting to read the whole chapter on *La Religion Paysanne*.

down to us through the past milleniums, and that its philosophical interpretation has been worked out in the conception and doctrines of yin and yang and feng shui" ²¹).

One point should be noted. In China there developed no great feminine deities associated with fecundity, such as we find in the Near East, in Astarte, Cybele, Ceres etc. Thus H. Maspero writes ²²), "Le dieu du Sol était la terre divinisée, mais pas à la manière de Cybele et des déesses-mères de l'Orient méditerranéen. On peut concevoir de deux façons la terre divinisée: ou bien comme la glèbe productrice de récoltes, et on en fait une terre-mère nourricière comme les peuples de l'Asie Antérieure; ou bien comme un territoire délimité soumis à un prince et sur lequel vivent des hommes, et on en fait un dieu protecteur du domaine princier et de ses habitants. C'est de cette manière que l'ont conçue les Chinois; et c'est pourquoi, à la différence des populations méditerranéennes, ils font de la terre un dieu et non une déesse." In both east and west, the spirit of vegetation was distinguished from the earth itself; *Mot* of the *Ras Shamra* texts, the Phrygian *Atys*, correspond to the 'Prince Millet' (Hou Chi 戶稷) of ancient China, as symbolizing the fruitage of the earth, but there the similarity seems to end. In China, the worship of Hou Chi, who was also thought of as the divine ancestor of the Chou dynasty, was associated with the worship of the patron gods of the soil, which took place, in particular at the spring and autumn festivals. The beautiful poem in the *Shih Ching*, which recounts the legend of Hou Chi ²³) speaks of his divine conception, his wondrous birth, his exposure, as an infant, to the elements and the protection afforded by animals and birds, and his gift to mankind of the products of husbandry. But there is no reference at all either to a cycle of death, disembodiment, burial and resurrection, or to sexual relations with feminine divinities associated with the earth by which the cycle of nature and the recurrence of fertility were symbolically depicted in Near Eastern religions.

The desire for fertility in man and beast, the desire for abundant

21) D. C. GRAHAM, art. *Mysterious potency in the Chinese Religion*, *Chinese Recorder*, April 1929, p. 235.

22) H. MASPERO, *Mélanges posthumes*, Vol. .I: *Les Religions Chinoises*, (Paris 1950), p. 21.

23) *The Book of Poetry*, *Shih Ching*, pt. 3, bk. 2, no. 1.

harvests from productive fields, was as strong in China as elsewhere. The concern for fertility is evidenced throughout their writings. No people has been more concerned to ensure offspring, and especially the continuance of the male line. Yet there is a remarkable absence of erotic cults designed to stimulate fertility.

In ancient Chinese religion the god of the soil seems to have held a position of paramount importance, and as a hierarchical structure of society developed each territorial unit had its own 'god of the soil' whose importance varied according to the size and importance of the territories over which he exercised control. As Chavannes writes ²⁴⁾, "Le dieu du sol est la personnification des énergies qui résident dans le sol. Chaque parcelle de sol a son dieu qui lui appartient en propre; mais la division du sol, étant déterminée par les groupements humains qui l'occupent, varie suivant l'extension de ces groupements; à ces répartitions diverses du territoire correspond toute une hiérarchie de dieux du sol". Though all the earth was considered sacred, a special spot was chosen on which a mound was erected, but not only a mound but a tree was required to represent the god. Thus Chavannes writes ²⁵⁾, "Le culte du dieu du sol n'exigeait pas seulement la présence d'un autel en terre; il lui fallait aussi un arbre." And again ²⁶⁾, "Dans la haute antiquité, l'arbre est chose essentielle sur l'autel du dieu du sol; bien plus, rien ne le distingue du dieu du sol lui-même; il est le dieu du sol. N'est-ce pas en effet dans l'endroit où s'élève un arbre de belle venue que sont concentrées toutes les vertus créatrices et nourricières du sol? Cet arbre ne jaillit-il pas du sein de la terre comme la vivante expression de sa fécondité?" The *Shuo Wen* mentions an ancient form of the ideograph for the earth mound, *she* (社) as 𡗗, showing that on the *she* altar a tree (木), suited to the type of soil, was planted. The philosopher Mo tzu writes, "Formerly in the time of the sacred kings of the three dynasties, when they first founded their kingdoms and established their capitals, they selected a site for the principal earth altar of the kingdom, erected the ancestral temple, and chose luxuriant trees to make a sacred grove" ²⁷⁾.

24) CHAVANNES, *op. cit.*, p. 437.

25) CHAVANNES, *op. cit.*, p. 466.

26) CHAVANNES, *op. cit.*, p. 471.

27) Mo tzu, *Chinese text. Sun Yi Jang's ed. in the Wan Yu Wen K'u*, Vol. 2, p. 151 (黑子閒話, by 詒孫讓).

Quaritch Wales suggests the possibility of Mesopotamian influence, and writes that "the representation of the Chinese god of the soil by mound and tree corresponds quite closely to Mesopotamian representations of Enlil and Tammuz ²⁸).

The gods of the soil were numerous. Each homestead had its own god of the soil who presided over the family possessions. These homesteads came to be grouped into villages or cantonments, ideally supposed to consist of twenty five families, and each of these groups had its 'god of the soil'. Above these were the feudal fiefs, and each territorial chief not only had an earth mound at which the god of his own family acres was worshipped, but another of greater significance, erected for the worship of the god who presided over the feudal domains. Into this mound a sod was incorporated which the feudal lord had received from the king at the time of his investiture. Finally, within the precincts of the imperial palace there was an altar to the god who was deemed to afford protection to the whole land. Thus, in the developed society of the Chou dynasty the gods of the homestead, the village, the fief and the empire formed a divine hierarchy corresponding to the human hierarchy on which it was superimposed. The sign of the complete extirpation of a feudal house was that its tree was cut down, and the mound built over so that it could no longer receive the beneficent influences of nature.

THE ORIGIN AND RISE OF KINGSHIP IN ANCIENT CHINA

Although Chinese tradition would place the origin of kingship away back in the third millenium B.C., and would attribute the beginnings of dynastic rule to Yü the Great, who founded the Hsia dynasty in 1989 B.C., we have no certain evidence of the establishment of a recognised kingship over a group of related tribes and clans before the Shang dynasty (circum 1558-1051 B.C.). Chinese tradition may not be far wrong, for the archaeological evidence from the An Yang excavations ²⁹) reveal that the Shang were already possessed of a highly developed bronze-age civilization, with such a well-developed written language, such a high degree of artistic expression and technical

28) QUARITCH WALES, *op. cit.*, p. 47.

29) Cf. H. C. CREEL, *Birth of China*, bk. 2; *Studies*, pp. 16 ff.

achievement as pre-supposes several hundred years of development ³⁰). Thirty names of Shang dynasty kings are listed in Ssu Ma Ch'ien's *Historical Records*, and as Chavannes has shown, Ssu Ma Ch'ien used the *Bamboo Records* as a source and considered them trustworthy. Scholars have identified twenty five of these names on the Shang Oracle bones, and thus we have contemporary evidence of the existence of a long line of Shang kings ³¹). The early Shang kings, and indeed the Chou Dynasty kings who followed them, differed widely in status and function from the emperors of the Han dynasty who arose after Ch'in Shih Huang Ti had unified the empire in 221 B.C. We must not be misled by Han dynasty scholars, who with perfectly sincere motives attributed to the earliest dynasties the concepts of kingship, and the elaborate ceremonial and ritual with which they themselves were familiar ³²). We know that the territories ruled over by the Shang hegemony were very limited in extent, and that right down to the middle of the 1st. millenium B.C., 1,000 years after the establishment of the Shang dynasty, the Chinese were not only exercised with the conquest of barbarian tribes on the borders, but that numerous tribes of the *Jung, I, Ti and Man*, regarded by the Chinese as uncivilized and barbarian, were living in territories closely adjacent to those over which the Chinese exercised control. The Chinese clans seem to have been distinguished from the barbarians in that the former possessed a common language, similar customs and habits, a common religion, and acknowledged the suzerainty of a supreme head ³³). Furthermore the Book of Poetry (Shih Ching) pictures for us the early chieftains of the Chou dynasty pioneering with their clans into new territories and clearing the forests and swamps in order to establish their encampments on virgin soil ³⁴).

The title given to the Shang ruler and to the early kings of the Chou dynasty was that of Wang (王), probably nothing more, in the first instant, than a pictograph of a man, standing or sitting in

30) FU SSU NIEN, *op. cit.*, Vol. 2, p. 20.

31) Cf. L. C. HOPKINS, Art. *Sovereigns of the Shang Dynasty*, *J.R.A.S.* 1917, pp. 69 ff.

32) Cf. M. GRANET, *Chinese Civilization* (London 1930), pp. 378 ff.

33) Cf. the numerous references in the *Shih Ching*, the *Shu Ching* and the *Tso Chuan* to the fighting against and assimilation of barbarian tribes.

34) Cf. especially the poems of the *Shih Ching* (pt. 3, book 1), Poems 3, 7 and 10.

a dignified position in ceremonial robes. As defined by later Chinese scholars the name signified a supreme ruler to whom all under Heaven (T'ien hsi: 天下) gave allegiance. The king was the one (一) by whom Heaven, Earth and Man (depicted by three strokes 三) were united. As he appears in the Shang dynasty, the supreme ruler won his position by force of arms and right of conquest, even as Chinese tradition records that T'ang, the founder of the dynasty, seized the throne by leading his followers to victory over the Hsia. The king established and maintained his position by means of alliances with the practically automatus clans which formed the Chinese hegemony³⁵). Shang society was based upon a clan structure, with classified kinship groups, and fraternal inheritance³⁶). It is probably quite true, as Granet maintains, that the concept of the kings being great masters of an national religion is entirely false, yet the contemporary evidence of the oracle bone inscriptions, and the archaeological finds which date from the Shang era, reveal that the king exercised important religious functions, which were considered essential for the well-being of the state. The primary duty of the king, in ancient times, and indeed of every territorial magnate, was that of preserving the prosperity of the land by means of acts of semi-magical nature, of ensuring the regular succession of the seasons, and maintaining a harmonious relationship between Heaven, Earth and man.

The oracle bone inscriptions³⁷) bear abundant testimony to the fact

35) Exogamous marriage seems to have been characteristic of the Chinese from earliest times. Young people bearing the same clan name could not marry. Marriage was a means of cementing relationships between various clans, and among the aristocracy tended to have great political significance. Cf. GRANET, *Chinese Civilization*, pp. 155 ff.

36) E. S. KIRBY, *Introd. to the Economic History of China* (London 1954), pp. 52-3.

37) Numerous works on the Oracle Bones have been written by Chinese scholars, notably by Lo Chen Ju and Tung Tso-Pin. For an account of the most important up to the time when his own work was published in 1938, see H. G. CREEL, *Studies in Early Chinese Cultures*, pp. 1-16. One of the most comprehensive is that of Sun Hai P'o (孫海波) called *Chia Ku Wen Pien* (甲骨文編). Since the war there has been a great development in archaeological research both by scholars in China and Formosa. *The Chan Hou Ching Chin Hsin Huo Chia Ku Chi* (戰後京津新獲甲骨集) and the 殷虛文字綴合 *Yin Hsü Wen Tzu Chiu Ho* have been

that the art of divining was considered of paramount importance, and for that purpose specialists in the art were appointed by the king and were associated with the court. They had the task of ascertaining, on all occasions, the will of the spirits of the royal ancestors, and the host of spiritual beings which took a keen interest in human affairs. On the other hand, the numerous characters connected with sacrifice, together with the sacrificial bronzes of superb workmanship, and of manifold and intricate design and use, which were produced during this period, bear witness to a highly developed sacrificial ritual, in which the king himself was the prime actor.

Of the mortuary faith current at this period we have meagre evidence, but such as it is it has a high significance. The excavation of numerous tombs of the Shang dynasty, several of which are believed to be royal, indicates that, at least among the aristocracy, there was not only a belief in some sort of life after death, but the conviction that the deceased king maintained a rank and status at least as exalted as that which he enjoyed in life. "The construction of one of the royal tombs", writes Creel³⁸) was no mean task. The beginning was the digging of a pit, in the case of the largest tomb forty three feet deep, and sixty five feet square... At the bottom of the pit a wooden tomb-chamber was constructed, about ten feet high and a little smaller than the bottom of the pit itself. The walls of this chamber were decorated, in places with almost incredibly fine carvings, in others with polychrome painted designs. Then the funeral was held, the body and other objects were put in place, and the whole excavation, every inch of the way to the surface, was filled with pounded earth..... The funeral was probably accompanied by the sacrifice of many human beings. It was, altogether, a ceremony not unfitting the passing of a king, and the inauguration of a royal ancestral deity". Accordingly there seems to be no doubt that, very early in Chinese history, the king exercised unique ritual functions which, on account of their importance to the welfare of all the people, gave to his person a semi-divine

published in Peking. For a study of some of the important questions raised by the oracle bone inscriptions see Kuo Mo Jo (郭沫若) *Chia Ku Wen Tzu Yen Chu* (甲骨文字研究). A periodical, the *K'ao Ku Hsüeh Pao*, (考古學報), devoted to archaeology, is published in Peking.

38) H. G. CREEL, *The Birth of China*, p. 177.

status, and that after death, he was honoured and worshipped as a divine being.

The religious acts of the king ensured the regularity of the seasons and the productivity of the soil, together with the fertility of crops and animals. In the environment of those early Chinese, nature was, on the whole, beneficent. The rich loess soil and the alluvial deposit of the great rivers were extraordinarily fertile. But the area was always subject to two major catastrophies, — floods and drought. The cosmic order, though usually dependable, was liable at times to catastrophic breakdowns. Among the earliest references in the *Book of History* mention is made of wide-scale flood³⁹). The emperor Yü, traditionally the first dynastic ruler, won his throne because of his success in flood and river control, while the myth of Shen Yi, (神羿) minister of Yao, (堯) shooting nine of the ten suns which were scorching the earth, reveals the great concern felt by the early Chinese in regard to the periodic droughts⁴⁰). Men might work on the land with skill and energy, but if the spring rains failed, or the summer brought disastrous floods, all their efforts were of no avail. They needed, in the person of their ruler, one who by virtue of his power and wisdom, and the efficacy of his prayers to the spirits, would prove a successful mediator.

The important religious functions which gave to the ruler his unique ritual status included the task of observing the movements of the heavenly bodies, and from them promulgating the calendar for the guidance and control of the seasonal activities of the people. These duties were performed on behalf of the ruler by a class of specially selected 'wise men'. Thus we are informed⁴¹) that the emperor Yao "commanded Hsi and Ho, reverently in accord with the will of Heaven, to calculate and represent the progress of the sun, moon and stars, so as to promulgate with care and reverence the appropriate times for men's work". In these functions of the ruler we see, perhaps, evidence that in still more primitive times the tribal ruler exercised an authority in virtue of his being wise man, astrologer, sorcerer,

39) J. LEGGE, *The Chinese Classics* (Hongkong 1865 ff.), Vol. 3, pt. 1, pp. 24-25.

40) Cf. E. C. WERNER, *Dict. of Chinese Mythology* (Shanghai 1932), p. 418.

41) J. LEGGE, *op. cit.*, Vol. 3, pt. 1, p. 18.

diviner and calendar-maker. This may have led to the belief, which meets us again and again in the literature of the Chou dynasty, that there was a golden age in the past, ruled over by sage kings of consummate virtue and wisdom, for the king, in early China, probably owed his unique position as much to the fact that he was the 'wise man' of his tribe, as to the fact that he was prime leader in war.

The tradition recording the accession of Shun, (舜) to be found in the *Book of History*⁴²), is of great interest as indicating that the succession was not hereditary in the most ancient times. According to that tradition, the emperor Yao asked his ministers to seek for a suitable candidate to succeed him. His own son was first suggested, and then the great minister of public works, but both were rejected. The chief of the princes was offered the throne but declined it. Then the whole assembly of ministers suggested Shun, a comparatively obscure man, bringing evidence of his outstanding virtue. After carefully testing Shun, the emperor, on the first day of the new year, handed over the administration to him before the tablet of his first ancestor. Shun thereupon began to perform his first duties as emperor. These were concerned with astronomy. Thereupon, he performed the *lei* (類) sacrifice to Shang Ti, worshipped the six (other) ancestor spirits whose tablets were set up in the ancestral shrine, together with the gods who presided over the mountains and rivers. Though this tradition comes to us from the Chou dynasty, when the glorification of the past was linked to a tendency to moralize history, it contains points of great interest.

In the first place, it hardly seems possible that the story was just 'invented' by court annalists and recorders of the W. Chou period, without having any basis at all in tradition, especially when we remember that hereditary succession became the rule, once the Chou rulers became firmly established over a feudalistic hierarchy. The apologists for the Chou kings had to prove that their displacement of the Shang dynasty was morally justifiable and in accordance with the will of Heaven. This seems to be, accordingly, the main theme of the early books of the *Shu Ching*. The Chou had risen to power from comparative obscurity. Such an event could only be explained as due to the

42) J. LEGGE, *op. cit.*, Vol. 3, pt. 1, pp. 23-27.

'Mandate of Heaven' having fallen upon them, just as, long before, Heaven had raised the obscure Shun to the throne because of its concern for the well-being of the whole people.

The narrative also reveals, not only the paramount importance of the cult of ancestors, but the central position of the king in a state ritual, in which the worship of Heaven and the host of spiritual beings was accompanied by an extraordinary interest in celestial phenomena, which were deemed to have a profound influence upon the seasonal life and activities of the people. The calendar was therefore of the utmost importance, endowed with religious significance and was the responsibility of the ruler.

M. Granet argues, from the fact that in the period of the Ch'un Ch'in, (circum 720-480 B.C.) the different war-lords did not use a single calendar system, that this important function only appertained exclusively to the Son of Heaven in later times, i.e. the Han dynasty ⁴³). But is it not possible that, in the period of the breakdown of centralized authority, the various feudal lords abrogated to themselves a privilege which had been considered the more exclusive prerogative of the king in an earlier period when he had been powerful enough to exert his suzerainty over the Chinese hegemony?

Though there seems to be no direct evidence of any custom, in ancient China, by which the king was slain when his physical powers began to decline, this tradition regarding Shun does seem to indicate that the aged king was forced to abdicate in favour of a younger man, usually chosen from among the leading nobility. Kingship did not proceed from father to eldest son until well after the establishment of the Chou dynasty. It was disputed among the leading nobles, and, in the case of Shun, a comparative outsider seized the power. The records seem to confirm this, for they speak of a serious rebellion breaking out, instigated by the highest ministers of the aged king ⁴⁴). Shun put down the rebellion and banished the chief instigators.

Soon after Shun entered upon his duties as king, we are told that he "thereupon performed the *lei* (類) sacrifice to Shang Ti" ⁴⁵).

43) M. GRANET, *Chinese Civilisation*, p. 382.

44) J. LEGGE, *op. cit.*, vol. 3, p. 1, p. 39.

45) J. LEGGE, *ibid.*, p. 33. (Note: Legge translates: "Thereafter, he sacrificed specially, but with the ordinary forms, to God; sacrificed purely to the six

This *lei* sacrifice seems to have been of a special nature, and was probably performed by each new king soon after his accession, the successful conclusion of the sacrifice denoting that he had been accepted and approved by the first and chief of the ancestor spirits, the chief God of the Chinese pantheon, Shang Ti (上帝). The character *lei* (類) is significant in that it is composed of three distinctive elements which suggest that, in this sacrifice, human beings were offered up, together with animals and the produce of the land. One constituent of that character is *mi* (米), a character used for rice, and for other grains such as maize and millet and even grasses. *Ch'uan* (犬) is a character believed to bear a resemblance to a dog, and is the indicator of a group of characters related to wild beasts. *Yeh* (頁), in its original form written *shou* (首) meaning 'head', over *jen* (人), meaning 'man', suggests that human sacrifice was part of the ritual. One might even throw out the suggestion that, in this component of the character *lei* (類), we have an indication, however, slight, that in very ancient times the aged king, who was head over the state, was actually sacrificed by his successor when declining vigour made him unfit to rule.

The question as to whether or not in the pre-Chou era before 1050 B.C. the Chinese had attained to a concept of a supreme deity, as was later designated by the terms T'ien (天) and Shang Ti (上帝) is still being debated. The belief held by many early sinologists that there was an early monotheism in China, subsequently lost, is to-day untenable. H. G. Creel believes that Heaven (*T'ien*, 天) was the supreme god of the Chous and was introduced by them into the religion of China. "I have shown," he writes, "that the character T'ien, as such, does not occur in the Shang oracle bone inscriptions, and that the deity T'ien had no part in Shang religion. It apparently originated among the Chou people and was brought east by them at the time of the conquest."⁴⁶) Again he writes, "Furthermore, the deity

honoured ones; offered their appropriate sacrifices to the hills and rivers; and extended his worship to the host of spirits." He comments on *lei* as denoting a sacrifice offered to the Highest, on an extraordinary occasion.)

⁴⁶) H. G. CREEL, *Studies*, p. 51.

Heaven is absolutely foreign to Shang culture.”⁴⁷⁾ Fu Ssu Nien argues⁴⁸⁾ that we cannot deduce from the absence of the word on the oracle bones, which are a highly specialized class of inscriptions dealing with divining the will of ancestor spirits, that the name and the concept were not used in Shang times. He claims that the Chou owed their culture to the Shang and with it their religion. He has made a thorough study of the use of the term *ti* (帝) on oracle bone inscriptions in 64 instances recorded by Sun Hai P’o in his *Chia Ku Wen Pien*, and comes to the conclusion that *ti* was used for the apotheosized royal ancestors and tribal gods, preceded usually by a name prefix, but that in 25 instances the word *ti* is used by itself, and clearly indicates the concept of a supreme *ti* who dwelt above in Heaven. In 17 other cases the word is used as a verb, to sacrifice, equivalent to the character *ti* (禘). The supreme *ti* was called upon for rain and good harvests. He sent punishment in the form of death and famine. He could grant his approval, bestow protection, and was clearly thought of as lord over all the other *ti* whether godlings or the spirits of former kings. Later this *ti* was equated with *t’ien* and received the sacrifice *ti* (禘). The word *shang* (上) was added, and under that name, *Shang Ti* (上帝), he was worshipped by the Chou.

It is an interesting and curious fact that in the early Chou literature, though the ancestry of the royal house is traced back to *Shang Ti*, the emperor is never referred to as the son of *Shang Ti*, but only as ‘Son of Heaven’ (*T’ien tzu*, 天子).

THE CONCEPT OF KINGSHIP UNDER THE CHOU

The ancient Shang hegemony gave place to the Chou dynasty about 1050 B.C. The Chou won their throne through military prowess and gradually established an hereditary succession, the kingship descending from father to son in a direct line. The earlier clan system of the Shang was absorbed into a feudal system, with a hierarchy of feudal relationships, and a family structure in which authority and loyalty tended to carry greater weight than love and affection. Respect for

47) *Ibid.*, p. 56.

48) FU SSU NIEN, *op. cit.*, vol. 2, p. 8.

age and ancestry developed. There was a high degree of centralized authority which went hand in hand with a devolution of functions. This social pattern was reflected in the religious concepts. It was during this early Chou period that the concept of an over-ruling Heaven became dominant, below which a host of spiritual beings had their appropriate places and functions in a transcendental hierarchy. In the early Chou literature Heaven is depicted as the supreme power, 'T'ien' (天), always thought of in the singular, and described as possessing many human attributes. Thus Heaven is compassionate, (*Shu Ching*, Pt. 5: 14, 2; *Shih Ching*, Pt. 2: 4, 10; Pt. 2: 5, 1.), he sends down prosperity, (*Shih*, Pt. 4: 3, 2.) is often terrible and angry, sending down ruin, (*Shih*, Pt. 2: 3, 11; Pt. 3: 3, 3; Pt. 3: 2, 10.). He gives birth to the people, (*Shih*, Pt. 3: 3, 1; Pt. 3: 3, 6) is father and mother of the people, (*Shih*, Pt. 2: 5, 4.) but is, in a special sense, the parent of the ruler (*Shih*, Pt. 2: 5, 3.).

Chinese scholarship has always tended to follow the *Shuo Wen* in explaining the character T'ien (天) in abstract terms, as an ideograph depicting what is above (—) man (大), but L. C. Hopkins and other western scholars have shown that the earliest known forms of the characters are pictograms representing the human form, (𠤎 𠤏 𠤐 𠤑 𠤒 𠤓). "It is submitted", writes Hopkins, "that this is an anthropomorphic design of a deity, perhaps conceived of as an apotheosized ancestor; at any rate the representation of God made in the image of man"⁴⁹). The altar for the worship of Heaven was never enclosed in a temple, but was open to the sky, and was round to symbolize heaven. This altar was never called the altar of Shang Ti, but always the altar of Heaven (T'ien). The ruler became the regent of Heaven upon earth, called the 'son of Heaven', and he alone was deemed worthy and adequate to render fitting worship to Heaven.

As the Chou ritual for the worship of Heaven and all the cosmic forces was elaborated, it absorbed into itself the rituals of more ancient times connected with ancestor worship and the fertility cults, and the place of the king in the ritual grew more and more important. The

49) Cf. L. C. HOPKINS, *Art. Pictorial Reconnaissances*, in *J.R.A.S.*, 1917, p. 774. See also H. G. CREEL, *Studies*, p. 97, note 2.

Ti (帝) who was the emperor's first ancestor, conceived of as a spiritual being dwelling in Heaven, became Shang Ti (上帝) and was equated with Heaven, (T'ien, 天) There are texts in the *Shih Ching* in which the two terms seem to be synonymous, e.g. the following passages:

"The people now amidst their perils
Look to Heaven (T'ien) all dark,
But let Heaven once determine,
And there is nothing it will not overcome.
There is the great God, (Shang Ti)
Does he hate anyone? ⁵⁰⁾"

"How vast is Heaven (T'ien), sovereign over all the people. Impetuous and haughty is God, (Shang Ti). He decrees many punishments. Heaven gave birth to the people, but their nature is undependable. All are good (at first), but few are able to remain so to the end. ⁵¹⁾"

In the period of the Western Chou (1050-771 B.C.), there seemed every likelihood that the status of the living king might be elevated so that he would come to be thought of as a 'god', to be accorded divine worship. Several legends became current which told of how the earliest kings were conceived by the direct operation of some divine being. *Hou Chi* (戶稷), the god of the millet, was proclaimed the divine ancestor of the Chou kings, so that divine blood flowed in their veins ⁵²⁾. Chinese mythology records the names several gods who were worshipped as patron gods of the soil and harvests, and known collectively as the *She Chi* (社稷). They included *Shen Nung* (神農), *Chu* (柱), *Ch'i* (棄), *Shu Chun* (叔均), and *Yin Hung* (殷洪) as well as *Hou Chi* (戶稷). They were, in all probability, the agricultural gods of the various tribes which made up the Chinese hegemony, and Hou Chi was the grain god of the Chou,

50) J. LEGGE, *op. cit.*, vol. 4, p. 2, bk. 4, No. 2.

51) *Ibid.*, p. 3, bk. 2, no. 1.

52) *Ibid.*, p. 3, bk. 2, no. 1.

whose land of origin was in the terraced loess regions of the west, where they cultivated the millet as their chief means of sustenance, and brewed from it an intoxicating drink. Later, when the Chou achieved the conquest of the other tribes, and overcame the Shang, their god, Hou Chi, was identified with *Ch'i* (稷), and all these tribal gods were linked into a family relationship and given the status of royal personages in the mythical dynasties of a bygone age⁵³).

The feudalistic system, with its elaborate social and religious ceremonial, and the increasing deference and homage paid to the supreme authority, tended towards the development of divine kingship. Already, as we see in several poems of the Shih Ching⁵⁴), the king was looked upon as the 'Son of Heaven', and as such performed certain unique religious functions on behalf of the whole state, and held an unique relationship to the supreme deity. He possessed within himself a latent quality or power, which was, in a measure, latent in all men, but in him to a superlative degree. This mana-like quality of *te* (德) was continually reinforced as he drew into himself the rich influences from the whole territory over which he exercised suzerainty, and as he held frequent and intimate communion with the spiritual forces which pervaded the universe. Through this power or virtue which the king possessed to an unique degree he extended his influence throughout the whole land, and, in so far as the influence was good, it was productive of a beneficent state of harmony and well-being. Consequently the king came to be thought of as possessing an aura of awe and majesty, so that everything he did, whether good or evil, exerted a powerful influence akin to that exerted by spiritual beings.

Why then, we might ask, was the development towards the full recognition of the emperor as a 'divine being', as happened very early in Egypt in the case of the Pharaohs, who were worshipped in life⁵⁵), arrested in China? The answer, I believe, lies in several factors, partly geographical, partly political and partly psychological.

Geographical conditions in N. China were very different from those appertaining in Egypt. Egypt was the valley and the delta of the Nile,

53) Cf. E. C. WERNER, *op. cit.*, pp. 412 ff.

54) J. LEGGE, *op. cit.*, vol. 4. See pt. 2, bk. 1: 8.3; bk. 3: 3.2; 6.3; bk. 7: 8.3 & 4. pt. 3, bk. 3: 8.5 — 6; 9.3 & 6. pt. 4, bk. 1: 1.8; 2.6; bk. 3: 4.7.

55) A. MORET, *The Nile and Egyptian Civilization*, London 1927, pp. 160-4, 168, 392-3.

a narrow strip of extraordinarily fertile land shut in between the inhospitable deserts. Though, from early times Egypt was subject to invasions from the Sudan, Lybia and Syria, once the whole land was brought under the centralized control of a powerful pharaoh, it became possible to concentrate power and wealth, to an extraordinary degree, in his hands. The land became 'Pharaoh's Land', and his control permeated everywhere. The whole economic life of Egypt was dominated by two powerful material phenomena, the sun and the Nile, and it is not difficult to conceive how the rituals by which the king ensured prosperity and fertility to the land gave to his person an unique 'divine status', so that in the Memphite monarchy 'divine kingship' became firmly established. With the decline of the Memphite monarchy, and the subsequent period of transition (circum 2485-2160 B.C.), we see a continual enroachment on the royal prerogatives, a decline in royal authority, a democratization of religion and a growth of scepticism and impiety; but 'divine kingship' had become so rooted in Egyptian thought that the Theban kings were able to regain something of the divine status of their predecessors. Yet the democratization of religion continued, and the Osirian mysteries came to be celebrated, not only for the benefit of the Pharaoh, but for all worshippers of Osiris, who shared in an eternal resurrection⁵⁶).

The period of the Western Chou, on the other hand, was one of almost unremitting warfare, concerned with the subjugation of barbarian tribes, and attempts to keep at bay the nomads of the northern steppes, who pressed down on the rich and fertile lands within the orbit of Chinese rule. The king needed to rely upon the military prowess of his semi-independent nobles, and those states which lay upon the periphery, if successful in war, tended to grow in extent of territory and in wealth. The royal domain, in the centre, had practically no opportunity for expansion, and in process of time the royal power tended to diminish in comparison with that of the feudal lords. With this decrease in material power there was a corresponding decrease in status and influence. It was not long before the predominant feudal lord was able to usurp temporal power, becoming what was called *pa* (霸), the chief or leader over an uneasy alliance of powerful states. For reasons of policy, the emperor, divested of real power, was allowed

56) A. MORET, *op. cit.*, p. 248.

to function in his religious capacities, and was acknowledged as supreme head of the state.

The Chinese in these early days revealed no tendency to anthropomorphize their gods. They seem to have been singularly deficient in the capacity to create myths to explain the origin of the universe and of human life. Like the Egyptians⁵⁷⁾ they recognised a first king of a first dynasty, and preceding him a dynasty of semi-divine beings, who had themselves succeeded rule by the gods. As in Mesopotamia, life was adapted to the cyclic succession of the seasons, and human society was organized to harmonize with nature through a recurring sequence of religious festivals. But here we notice one fundamental difference. There is no apparent cosmic clash between the dual powers of light and darkness, order and chaos, life and death. In China the duality which arises out of a primal unity is a duality of equally necessary and beneficent forces, which in turn attain ascendancy in the seasonal process. There is, therefore, no need to postulate a dramatic strife between the divine and the demonic, the cosmic and the chaotic, such as we see in Mesopotamian thought. Thus, in China, the dragon, regarded from earliest times as a powerful deity, was not a malevolent monster, a personification of the powers of evil ruling over a primeval abyss, which needed to be slain by some divine hero, but was rather an awe-inspiring being whose activities were, on the whole, beneficent to mankind. Through the winter months he inhabited the rivers and lakes, and in spring he mounted up to heaven, to ride upon the mighty storm clouds, and to send down the rain which was so necessary for fertility and growth. He thus became identified with the powers of fertility and production. He became king over the spiritual beings which inhabited the world of nature, and very early in China, the king was thought of as possessing attributes analogous to those of the dragon. He possessed a 'dragon nature', majestic, terrible and awe-inspiring, and yet, by his power and virtue, he brought well-being, prosperity and happiness to all the people over whom he exercised his rule. The dragon motive was embroidered on the royal robes and the royal banners. The king possessed a dragon countenance and sat upon the dragon throne. The superb horses, which in later times drew the royal chariot, were likened to dragons, and it is possible that the

57) H. FRANKFORT, *op. cit.*, p. 15.

search for the Heavenly horses of Ferghana grew out of the belief that the emperor would ascend to Heaven upon a chariot drawn by dragon-like beings. The dragon as the symbol of royalty is understandable when we remember that in Chinese thought the emperor possessed divine qualities similar in potency and effect to those ascribed from earliest times to the dragon. Throughout Chinese history the dragon has been worshipped as a god, and even to the present day the temple of the Dragon King (Lung Wang Miao, 龍王廟) is a prominent feature in many N. China villages. That this worship is a primitive feature in Chinese religion is evidenced by Creel, who informs us that in the Chia Pien lists of oracle bone inscriptions no less than 41 characters are considered to be form of *lung* (龍), meaning dragon⁵⁹), whilst Andersson affirms that the dragon motive appears in the earliest forms of Chinese art. Rostovtzeff believed that the dragon motive came to China from the Babylo-Assyrian civilization by way of Iran, but, if so it must have been very early, as the dragon motive appears in Kansu early in the 2nd. millenium B.C.⁶⁰).

In China, as in Egypt, the world was understood "in dualistic terms as a series of pairs of contrasts balanced in unchanging equilibrium. The universe as a whole was referred to as 'heaven and earth' "⁶¹). Man must assist, by means of religious ceremonies, the *yang* (陽) forces to overcome the *yin* (陰) forces in the spring and early summer, but he must help the *yin* to rise to ascendancy in autumn and winter. These two forces, which permeated all natural phenomena, and by their constant interaction caused all things to subsist, arose out of a primaeval cosmic unity. Neither of these two forces were conceived of in China in personalized terms, as in Mesopotamia, and there did not develop in China the concept of a cosmic struggle between the powers of light and darkness, resulting in the final triumph of the forces of light. In the ritual by which the emperor maintained the cosmic balance, as described in the *Li Chi*⁶²) it was just as

59) H. C. CREEL, *Studies*, p. 237.

60) ROSTOVITZEFF, *The Animal Style in S. Russia and China* (Princetown 1929).

61) H. FRANKFORT, *op. cit.*, p. 19.

62) See, e.g. *The li Chi*, bk. 4, Section 2, Pt. 2, Par. 15; bk. 4, section 4, Pt. 1. Par. 19; bk. 4, section 4, Pt. 2. Par. 7, 10.

essential to guarantee the ascendancy of *yin* in its season, as it was to guarantee the ascendancy of the *yang*. Whatever dualism existed in Chinese thought was a dualism of complementary forces which worked to produce cosmic harmony, and not a dualism of antagonistic forces bent on each other's destruction.

Moreover, in China, the significance of man has not been greatly emphasised⁶³). He was part, but a very small part, of the cosmos, deriving his nature from a union of elements compounded of heaven and earth. At death, those two elements which formed his nature tended to disintegrate, and to be reabsorbed into the *yin* and the *yang*. This tendency of the Chinese to interpret man in terms of his relation to cosmic forces, rather than to interpret cosmic forces in relation to man, militated against the tendency, so common among other peoples, towards the anthropomorphization of their gods. Had they been able to develop the worship of a personalized sun god or moon goddess, or had they been able to conceive of their gods as did the ancient Greeks in respect of the Olympian deities, the hypostasization of a god in the person of their emperor might not have been difficult.

There is evidence that, in the early Chou period, the religious functions of the emperor mainly centred in a building which is known to us in the *Li Chi* as the Hall of Brightness, or *Ming T'ang* (明堂). This building possessed something of the nature of a 'calendar house', and is believed by some scholars to have had a very early origin⁶⁴). The earliest reference to the building is in Mencius⁶⁵), where it had already fallen into disuse. The T'ai Miao (太廟) referred to in the Confucian *Analects*⁶⁶) was probably the same building, and tradition records that it went under different names

63) This is particularly revealed in Chinese paintings, in which, so often, man is dwarfed into insignificance amidst the immensities of nature; cf. *Chinese Art*, ed. by LEIGH ASHTON (London 1935), pp. 6, and 23.

64) See particularly: J. LEGGE, *Sacred Books of the East. The Li Chi*, Chapter on the Ming T'ang.

W. E. SOOTHILL, *Hall of Light* (London 1951), pp. 66 ff.

A. BULLING, *The Meaning of China's most ancient Art* (Leiden 1952), pp. 116-117.

65) J. LEGGE, *The Life and Works of Mencius* (London 1875), p. 147.

66) *The Analects of Confucius*, bk. 3: 10, 15. bk. 10: 14. A convenient translation is that by A. WALEY (London 1938), pp. 96, 98, and 150.

at different times. Confucius, when visiting the building, was evidently at a loss as to the meaning of the various symbolic and ritualistic objects, which seems to indicate that, though the temple still stood, its purpose and function were no longer clearly understood. Perhaps the only safe conclusion that can be drawn from the available evidence is that, in the Ming T'ang, the Chou emperor performed an unique function in harmonizing the seasonal life and activities of his people with the movements of the heavenly bodies, and the progression of the seasons in nature. Because of this his person was regarded with peculiar awe and sanctity by the people. But with the break-up of the empire, and the usurpation of power by the great feudal lords, the unique magico-religious status of the emperor in relation to the spiritual world tended to disappear, along with the growth of sceptical thought, which has tended to characterize the Chinese ever since.

DIVINE KINGSHIP AND CH'IN SHIH HUANG TI.

The only other period in Chinese history when there seemed to be the possibility of according to the emperor the status and worship of a divine being was at the time when Ch'in Shih Huang Ti finally subjugated the last of the warring states, and established an empire under one supreme head in 221 B.C. During the collapse of feudalism in the period of the warring states (5th.-3rd. century B.C.), the political tendency was towards government by rulers possessing absolute power, and this tendency found its completion in Ch'in Shih Huang Ti. Already in the state of Ch'in, which he ruled, under the influence of a school of Legalists, known as the *Fa Chia* (法家), the theory of the absolute authority and the divine right of the king had been vigorously expounded. The great Confucian philosopher, Hsün Tzu, (3rd century B.C.), having taught the Confucian doctrine that supreme rule and authority should be in the hands of the most virtuous, went on to teach that his word was absolute law: "Therefore to be emperor, be the right man. The empire is the weightiest thing there is. Only the strongest man is able to bear its weight. It is the largest of all. Only the most discriminating is able to make its proper distinctions. It is the most populous. Only the most wise is able to harmonize it. Unless he is a sage, he will not be able to fulfil these three requirements. Hence, unless he is a sage, he will not be able

to rule as a true king" 67). "The emperor's authority and position are most honourable, and he has no peer in the empire..... His virtue is pure and complete; his wisdom and kindness are most illustrious. When he faces south (i.e. seated on his throne), and rules the empire, all living people are moved to obey and yield to his influence. Then the empire has no (wise) men in retirement, nor are good men neglected. *What is in accord with his acts is right: what differs from them is wrong*" 68).

This glorification of the position and power of the absolute ruler was carried further by two disciples of Hsün Tzu, namely Han Fei Tzu and Li Ssu, both of whom had great influences on Ch'in Shih Huang Ti. Thus Han Fei Tzu writes, "The intelligent ruler carries out his regulations as would Heaven, and employs men as if he were a spirit. Being like Heaven, he commits no wrong. Being like a spirit, he falls into no difficulties. His power ('shih' 勢) prevails. His instructions are severe. Though they may feel rebellious, none dare disobey" 69).

When Ch'in Shih Huang Ti came to the throne he soon gave evidence that he intended to play the role of a divine ruler. One of his first acts was to proclaim himself 'Shih Huang Ti', the first emperor. In assuming this title he was deliberately appropriating to himself a term which had been used in previous dynasties either for the divine spirits of deceased emperors, or for the supreme deity of the Chinese pantheon. The term *ti* (帝) 70), possibly in its earliest form depicting a sacrifice, or a majestic figure in sacrificial robes, was not used to designate the reigning monarch, but only for the spirits of apotheosized ancestors. Later, in the Chou dynasty, *Shang Ti* (上帝) the supreme ruler above, became more or less equated

67) Hsün Tzu, *Chinese Text*, Wan Yu Wen K'u ed. (Shanghai 1930), p. 90.

荀子寓有文庫

68) *Ibid*, p. 96.

69) Han Fei Tzu, *Chinese text*, Wan Yu Wen K'u ed. (Shanghai 1929), p. 44.

韓非子集解, 萬有文庫.

70) For a full discussion of the title Shih Huang Ti and the development of the use of the term 'ti' see D. BODDE, *China's First Unifier*, (Leiden 1933), chapter 6.

with the supreme deity, Heaven *T'ien* (天). With the character *ti* (帝) the new emperor associated the character *huang* (皇), written more anciently (皇), signifying one who rules by his own absolute authority. *Shih* (始), meaning beginning or first, reveals that the ruler of Ch'in was claiming to inaugurate a lasting dynasty which would be different in kind from anything that had gone before. It was to last for ten thousand generations. The full title *Shih huang ti*, reveals that the ruler of Ch'in wished to be recognised as a divine emperor, whose power and virtue, pervading the whole empire, would correspond on earth to the power and virtue of Heaven above.

But the emperor was conscious of his mortality, and so he began that restless search for the drug or elixir of immortality by which he was assured that he would become immortal. He felt sure that the spirits above would not refuse this boon to one so illustrious as himself. He made several attempts to get into direct contact with the powerful spirits. Finally, becoming convinced that his failure was due to his preoccupation with the weighty affairs of state, he retired into seclusion from his people, believing that in this way he would best cultivate his divine nature. Then he began to have prepared for himself a magnificent mausoleum, reminding us of the pyramids of the early pharaohs, in which he might hope to enjoy a kingly estate after death. Thousands of workmen toiled on this structure. On a foundation of bronze a stone sarcophagus was raised, surrounded by a whole empire in miniature, palaces and ministries, towns and villages, even trenches filled with mercury to represent rivers and streams, the mercury being made to flow by means of an ingenious machine. On the vault of the tomb chamber were depicted the firmament and the host of stars ⁷¹).

This attempt to give the emperor a divine status, no doubt engineered by ambitious ministers and eunuchs for their own purposes, was doomed to failure, for the humanistic and rationalistic philosophies which had been developing throughout the preceding centuries were entirely alien in spirit to the magico-religious cult of emperor worship.

Nevertheless, with the establishment of an unified empire, the

71) For a French transl. of the texts concerned see L. WEIGER, *Textes Historiques* (Hien-Hien 1929), p. 225.

development of an elaborate state cult was inevitable, and in that state cult the function of the emperor was of central importance. Therefore, during the Han dynasty (206 B.C.-225 A.D.), which followed upon the fall of Ch'in the practices of former times were elaborated into a most detailed and intricate ritual which was to become normative for all subsequent times right down to the twentieth century. This corpus of ceremonial and ritual by which the state cult of China was regulated was gathered together by Han scholars to form the *Book of Rites*, the *Li Chi*, which formed an important part of the Confucian Canon.

KINGSHIP FROM THE HAN DYNASTY ONWARDS.

From the Han dynasty onwards, whatever the personal predilections of the emperor might be — he was often predisposed to Taoism or Buddhism —, it was considered indispensable to the well-being of the empire, conceived of as the entire civilized world, that a harmonious relationship should be maintained between Heaven, Earth and man. This relationship could only be maintained unimpaired if the emperor performed with deep reverence, and with careful attention to the minutest detail, as son of Heaven, the sacred and sacrificial ritual which was believed to have been originated in hoary antiquity. Yet it must be emphasised that it was as man, in sight of Heaven a very humble and even abject man, that the emperor performed those high-priestly functions which only he, as unique man, could perform. These ritual acts consisted of the worship of Heaven in the south suburb of the capital at the winter solstice, the worship of earth at the special altar of the Lord of the soil of the whole empire, the worship of innumerable spirits of mountains and rivers and natural forces at appropriate seasons, and the worship of the divine ancestors of the dynasty in the ancestral temple. Furthermore, associated with the emperor were high officials charged with astronomy, divining, prognostication and the preparations of the calendar. The following quotations from the *Book of Rites*, the *Li Chi*, help us to see the unique place of the emperor in the ritual.

“The ancient kings were troubled lest the ceremonial usages should not be generally understood by all below them. They therefore sacrificed to God in the suburb of the capital, and thus the place of Heaven

was established. They sacrificed at the Altar of Earth inside the capital, and thus they imitated the benefits derived from the earth. Their sacrifices in the Ancestral Temple gave their fundamental place to the sentiments of humanity. Those at the altar of the hills and streams served to mark their intercourse with the spirits breathing (in nature). Their five sacrifices of the house were a recognition of the various businesses that had to be done ⁷²).

"The emperor forms a ternion with Heaven and Earth, and stands side by side with spiritual beings, in order to the right ordering of government ⁷³).

"The Son of Heaven forms a ternion with Heaven and Earth. Hence, in power of his goodness, he is their correlate, and his benefit extends at once to all things. His brilliance is equal to that of the sun and moon, and enlightens all within the four seas ⁷⁴).

From the *Book of Rites*, we gather that all the ceremonial garments, the jade tokens and other regalia, the sacrificial vessels themselves, all had symbolic significance in aiding the success of the ritual and the sacrifices. There grew up an elaborate mimetic or sympathetic symbolism. The human world was thought of as a microcosm which reflected and was intimately connected with the macrocosm of the universe.

It was not alone in his position as high-priest of the state cult that the emperor of China was unique, but also in his status as supreme ruler of the terrestrial universe, owing his appointment to Heaven above. The rationalistic and humanistic tendencies of Confucian thought, which led the scholar-official to despise as gross superstitions the personalized gods of popular Taoism and Buddhism, made it equally impossible for him to give to his reigning emperor the status and dignity of a god. But the hierarchical pattern of the society over which the emperor was supreme head, together with an emphasis on an elaborate state cult, centring in the emperor, led to an adulation of the emperor and a sacred regard for his person which, practically speaking, fell little short of divine worship. Though legends grew up to account for the divine origin of the dynastic lines, it is doubtful if the scholar class regarded these legends as anything but imaginative

72) J. LEGGE, *Sacred Books of the East, The Li Chi*, book 7, section 4. 2.

73) *Ibid*, bk. 7, section 13.

74) *Ibid*, book 23, section 3.

fables, useful to invest the person of the emperor, in the eyes of a credulous populous with an aura of supernatural majesty. There was nothing analogous to the Japanese theory which claimed for the mikado descent from the sun-goddess, Amaterasu. In what sense, then, could the emperor be thought of as the 'Son of Heaven'? Only in the sense that it was in the nature of things, through the inexorable interplay of the cosmic forces which produced all natural phenomena, and which likewise controlled human affairs, that the emperor and his dynasty were raised to the position of supreme authority over terrestrial affairs. It was part of the pre-ordained order that one man should reign supreme on earth, and the emperor happened to be that man. Yet, in pursuance of his unique office and function, the emperor stood in an unique relationship to Heaven, which was best described as 'son of Heaven'. On the one hand he was the special object of Heaven's beneficence and protective care, and, on the other hand, he alone was worthy to express to Heaven in prayer and sacrifice both the gratitude and the needs of mankind. As Son of Heaven the emperor's every word was law. His every wish and whim must be obeyed. He could do no wrong. In his presence the highest official must prostrate himself, and, when told to rise, look with downcast eyes, holding his tablet before his mouth when speaking, lest his breath should contaminate the august person of his lord. Even in remonstrance it must never be hinted that the emperor had done wrong, or even been mistaken. All mistakes were those of his ministers who had failed to interpret correctly the royal will, or had given evil advice. At a word from the royal lips the most powerful ministers might be degraded to a minor post, sent into distant exile, or forced to commit suicide. When the emperor died, after the appropriate ceremonies of interment had been completed, he was raised, as his posthumous title so often suggests, to the rank of a divine being, and his spirit tablet found its place in the ancestral temple besides those of his illustrious ancestors.

CONCLUSION

The concept of kingship in China was, therefore, throughout historic times, always dominated by a philosophy which conceived of the universe as a constant and continuous interplay of cosmic forces, ever in process of endless transformations, yet circling around a fixed

centre, which, itself perfectly quiescent, nevertheless caused all things to move, which itself inactive inspired the 'myriad things' to perpetual activity. The function of the emperor was to study to conform himself and all under him to the invariable and pre-determined laws of the natural universe, to keep in perfect harmony with them, to sit on his throne at the centre of the world of men, and 'with his face towards the south' rule simply by reigning. Any deviation on his part from a pre-determined pattern would be reflected in the confusions which arose in the natural sphere, resulting in insurrections, plagues, famines and potents of nature. If the emperor should persist in deviation from the norm it might even be necessary for his mandate to be taken away from him and from his house, and for another to be appointed by Heaven to take his place. So long as he remained emperor, all honour, respect and dignity were accorded to him, as the 'unique man', the vice-regent of Heaven, the one in whom all the well-being and prosperity of mankind were centred. At death, his vital spirit continued its interest in and concern for the people which he had governed on earth, and though now exalted to some position of honour in the heavenly sphere, so long as his descendants continued to reign and to offer appropriate sacrifices, he still continued to give his guidance and counsel.